

How to choose a niche for your video business

You don't have a lead problem, you have a "who am I for" problem. Your niche is usually already sitting in your own numbers: the sector where your profitable, repeat work from the last twelve months clusters, chosen on fit and proof, not on imagined budget. Write it as one sentence and test it with the people it describes before you change a word on your website.

Why does "I need more leads" turn out to be a "who am I for" problem?

"I need more leads" is the symptom most owners report, and the cause usually sits upstream: nobody has decided who the business is for, so no message lands with anyone in particular. In my client avatar workshop it's the example objective on the slide: "We just need more leads."

You can't market with force when you haven't decided who you're for, because nobody can see themselves in a message trying to speak to everyone. The indecision upstream caps everything downstream.

One of the most capable owners I've worked with couldn't choose. Established, profitable, excellent work. He loves customer success videos: creative, well paid, a range of industries. He also has a large existing relationship in government internal comms, which could be bigger and quicker because the relationship already exists. So he talks himself into one, then straight back out. While he debates, nothing compounds. He thinks his problem is leads.

Niche paralysis wears two disguises:

- **Chasing the highest payer.** "I want whoever pays the most" keeps you stuck, because money isn't a niche, and a prospect needs a reason to choose you beyond your willingness to take their cash.

- **Over-polishing the positioning.** One member spent hours refining a single tagline, word by word, before catching herself: "I've spent way too much time on this."

Both are the same fear wearing different clothes. Choosing a niche means closing doors, and closing doors feels like loss.

Why does committing to one market pay?

Committing to one market pays because you stop spreading your energy across markets, and your margin rises once you know one industry well.

First, energy. Chase two rabbits and you catch neither, and chasing lots of different markets and opportunities does the same thing to your focus.

Second, margin. When you work for one industry, you learn exactly what they want and need. Most of them aren't looking for a feature film. They want the job done well and quickly, and the more you niche down into a particular industry, the more your margin rises.

Third, language. Every industry has its own nomenclature. Learn it and you show up talking their language, while every other production company is still talking about gear, coffee chats and telling a story. When you try to market to everyone, you speak to no one.

How to find your niche in your last twelve months of work: the method, step by step

The method is an audit of every job from the last twelve months, scored on margin and repeat, then checked for fit, proof and more than one buyer before you write it down as a hypothesis. It uses numbers you already have.

1. **List every job from the last twelve months.** Pull them from your invoicing: client, sector, what you charged, what it cost in days and crew, and the margin left. Estimate margin in round numbers if you don't track it, and say so. The [Client Profitability Calculator](#) ranks them by profit per day.

2. **Mark each row: repeat or one-off, and would you do it again.** The gut answer is data. A job you'd never repeat is telling you something about the sector, the buyer or the price.
3. **Circle the cluster.** Sort by margin. Where do the high-margin, repeat, "yes, again" rows sit? Usually one sector, sometimes two. The producer above didn't need to invent a niche; his most profitable, repeatable work was already in his own numbers. Whether that work is one relationship or a sector is the check in step 5.
4. **Check the cluster for fit and proof.** Do you already win there, with results to point to? Can you describe the buyer's world better than they can? Do you speak their language?
5. **Check there's more than one buyer.** One large relationship is a client, and a client can leave. A niche has more than one organisation hiring the same way and an ongoing need to communicate. Do businesses in that sector already have video on their websites, LinkedIn pages and socials? Who is the one person who hires videographers, and what is their job title? If you can only find one buyer so far, the cluster is a strong client and the sector still needs testing.
6. **Write the hypothesis.** One sentence: who you help, the result they get, the offer that gets it. The test in the next section decides the final wording.

Copy and paste: the twelve-month job audit

Job 1: Client / Sector / Charged \$ / Margin \$ / Repeat or one-off / Would I do it again?

Job 2: Client / Sector / Charged \$ / Margin \$ / Repeat or one-off / Would I do it again?

(continue for every job in the last twelve months)

The sector where margin, repeat and "yes" overlap:

Results I can already point to in that sector:

The one person who hires video there, by job title:

Evidence they already use video (where I saw it):

Copy and paste: the niche-message-offer hypothesis

We help [who: the sector and the person who hires] get [result: the outcome in their words] through [offer: the specific video service that gets it].

Illustrative example of the shape: "We help [training managers at regional airports] get [new staff inducted and compliant] through [a library of short induction and safety videos]."

How to test the hypothesis without rebranding

Test the hypothesis by saying it to the people it describes, clients and prospects inside the cluster, before you touch your website, your company name or your reel. Their reactions and their words set the final sentence, and the website copy comes after.

1. **Pick a few people inside the cluster.** Current clients, past clients and prospects you can reach warmly, each one the person who hires video or close to them. Three is a sensible number to start with, as a suggestion rather than a rule.
2. **Say the sentence and ask the questions.** Use the script below. Record the call if they agree, then transcribe it and pull out the key points, because their words are the copy you'll use later. Don't lead the answer and don't defend the sentence. If you're only getting short answers, ask "what else?" and let them speak.
3. **Rewrite the sentence in their words.** Where they recognised the problem, keep it. Where they described the result differently, use their version. Where they couldn't say who hires, find out before you go further. When the sentence stops changing between conversations, it's ready for your LinkedIn profile and your website.

Copy and paste: the hypothesis test script

"I'm tightening up who we work for, and you're exactly the kind of person I want to get this right for. Can I read you one sentence and ask you three questions? It won't take long."

[Read the hypothesis sentence, then stop talking.]

1. "Does that describe a problem you actually have, or a problem you think other people have?"

2. "If you were describing the result you want from video to your boss, what words would you use?"

3. "When video gets hired in your organisation, who makes that call, and what's their title?"

"What else?" [Wait.]

"Would you mind if I sent you the revised sentence once I've spoken to a few other people?"

What if the work in my niche is confidential and I can't show it?

Prove it by outcome. When the terms of the work prohibit showing it, build the case study on what changed: the result you delivered and the problem you solved.

This stops a lot of people committing to a niche they already dominate, especially in government, healthcare and internal comms. The producer's terms prohibit displaying his government work. A case study that says what the client needed, what you made and what happened after it went out still gives a buyer in that sector a reason to hire you. Proof doesn't have to be a showreel.

A worked example

Here's the audit on an illustrative year of twenty jobs, in round numbers. The owner, the sectors and the figures are invented for the example.

Sector	Jobs	Margin per job (average)	Repeat or one-off	Again?
Airport and aviation services training	8	\$5,000	3 clients, all repeat	Yes
Brand films (mixed sectors)	4	\$6,000	One-off, each a new hunt	Yes
Events and one-off corporate	8	\$1,500	One-off	No

Brand films have the best margin per job, which is why they feel like the answer, but each of those four jobs was a separate sale into a separate industry with no route to the next one. The aviation cluster carries \$40,000 of margin from three clients that keep coming back, and the hirer has the same job title each time. Events is \$12,000 of margin from eight jobs the owner wouldn't do again, and it's been filling the calendar.

The hypothesis written off that table is the aviation one. The owner still takes brand films when they come in. The marketing points at one buyer.

The mistakes that undo it

The audit goes wrong in four predictable ways.

- **Choosing the exciting work over the profitable work.** The job you enjoyed most and the biggest one-off cheque both stand out in memory. Neither is the cluster unless the margin and the repeat column say so.
- **Stopping at the big names.** If the largest organisations in a sector use agencies, look along the supply chain. In aviation the airlines have agencies, but airports and the services they rely on (training, safety, staff induction, compliance, maintenance) may well have a need for video. Look at where video is already being used.

- **Testing with the wrong person.** A friendly contact who doesn't hire video will agree with anything. Find out whether it's the marketing manager, the HR manager or several people, and put the sentence in front of the one who decides.
- **Treating the niche as a ban on other work.** The niche decides where your marketing points. You can still take the odd job outside it.

The rule of thumb for choosing a niche

Niche where your margin and your repeat work already overlap in your own numbers. Tactics decay. Identity persists. The owner who commits to "I am the person who does this, for these people" changes his behaviour permanently, because the decision is made and everything downstream gets easier.

Hold yourself accountable

Which of these have you taken on or put in place recently?

- You have a list of the last twelve months of jobs with a margin figure against each one.
- You can say, by job title, who hires video in your chosen sector.
- You've written the hypothesis sentence and said it out loud to at least one person who fits it.
- Your last three marketing actions pointed at the same sector.

Your one move this week

What's the one thing you can commit to implementing this week? If you're not sure, start here.

Build the twelve-month job list. Open your invoicing, fill in the worksheet above (round numbers where you have to) and circle the rows where margin, repeat and "yes, again" overlap. Don't write the sentence yet. Look at the circle first, because it's probably the decision you'd already half made.

One thing executed every week creates 50 strategic moves a year.

Questions like these come up regularly on our weekly Elite Boardroom calls. If you'd like someone to hold you to account each week, and to learn from a group of peers who run video businesses too, [the Boardroom is for you](#).

Related tools and guides. [Client Profitability Calculator](#) (rank the clients you already have by profit per day), [How to use your own story to position your video business](#) (the background you already have is often the niche), [One client dependency](#) (when the cluster is a single relationship), [Qualify before you pitch](#), [Know your numbers](#).



The field guides show you how the system works. The Boardroom is where I look at your business with you, give you perspective and judgement on what to do next, and hold you to it every week.

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